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Mik Wisniewski

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Perspectives

Using SERVQUAL to assess customer satisfaction with public sector services

Mik Wisniewski

The author

Mik Wisniewski is Senior Research Fellow at the Department of Management Science, University of Strathclyde, Glasgow, UK and Performance Audit Division, Audit Scotland, Edinburgh, UK

Keywords

Service quality, Customer satisfaction, Public sector, Value

Abstract

The UK Government's Best Value initiative is intended to ensure that local authorities provide best value in service delivery and emphasises the importance of ensuring a clear customer/citizen focus across all services. Local authorities are already using a variety of methods to capture the voice of the customer, with customer surveys being one of the most popular. Such surveys, however, have tended to focus solely on customers' perceptions of services and not their expectations. This paper presents the results of using an adapted SERVQUAL approach across a range of Scottish council services. The results of the studies will be discussed, the use of SERVQUAL results by service managers reviewed and the contribution of SERVQUAL to continuous improvement assessed.

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Introduction

Scotland's 32 local authorities are responsible for the provision of wide range of public services to a resident community of over 5 million people and spend around £7 billion each year (Scottish Local Government Information Unit, 2000). Local authorities – and most other public sector bodies in the UK – have not been immune from the revolution that has swept through much of the commercial service sector over the few years (Burns, 1992; Skelcher, 1992; Speller and Ghobadian, 1993a, 1993b; Glynn and Murphy, 1996; Philip and Stewart, 1999). In the private sector, customer satisfaction and loyalty – secured through high-quality products and services which meet customer needs and which provide value for money – are seen as essential for survival, let alone success. Organisations operating in the public sector have also come to realise that they must ensure their services are soundly based on the needs and expectations of their stakeholders – communities, citizens and customers – and that they are seen as providing service quality. Since 1997, this has been reinforced by the UK Government's commitment to the modernisation of local government with radical change proposed to the way councils plan and deliver local services through best value (Filkin, 1997; Department of the Environment, Transport and the Regions, 2000). Best Value in Scotland emphasises the role of sound management as a means of delivering service improvements (Scottish Office, 1997, 1998). The Accounts Commission and Audit Scotland, who have statutory audit responsibilities for local government, have set out ten key criteria of a best value service (Accounts Commission for Scotland, 1999a; Wisniewski and Stewart, 2001). Deliberately, the first of these is "understanding the needs, expectations and priorities of all stakeholders".

Service quality and customer satisfaction in the public sector

Service quality is a concept that has aroused considerable interest and debate in the research literature because of the difficulties

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Managing Service Quality
Volume 11 · Number 6 · 2001 · 380–388

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in both defining it and measuring it with no overall consensus emerging on either (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1985; Lewis and Mitchell, 1990; Dotchin and Oakland, 1994a, 1994b; Gaster, 1995; Asubonteng *et al.*, 1996). There are a number of different "definitions" as to what is meant by service quality. One that is commonly used defines service quality as the extent to which a service meets customers' needs or expectations (Lewis and Mitchell, 1990; Dotchin and Oakland, 1994a; Asubonteng *et al.*, 1996; Wisniewski and Donnelly, 1996). Service quality can thus be defined as the difference between customer expectations of service and perceived service. If expectations are greater than performance, then perceived quality is less than satisfactory and hence customer dissatisfaction occurs (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1985; Lewis and Mitchell, 1990).

Local authorities in Scotland are already engaged in a variety of innovative approaches to capture the "voice of the customer" – local area forums, citizens' juries, etc. Increasingly, many authorities are also conducting market research surveys of one form or another. These are often a useful first step for services trying to capture data on current levels of customer satisfaction with services. While such surveys report levels of satisfaction with public sector services they do little to assess whether customer needs and expectations are actually being met (Accounts Commission, 1999b). This is because many of these surveys tend to focus solely on customer perceptions of service – measuring what the customer thinks of the service they are currently getting. Such an approach fails to measure customer expectations of service delivery and an adequate understanding of customer expectations is essential for performance improvement. As Skelcher (1992) comments:

> The limitation of this (type of) market research, however, is that it has tended to focus on satisfaction with existing services rather than identifying customers' needs, whether these are being met and, if not, what steps the authority might take to fulfil them.

Donnelly and Shiu (1999) also comment that:

> ... the expectations of ... citizens generally are continually shifting upwards, with a greater emphasis placed on the quality of service. Levels of service which may have been tolerated only a generation ago are now regarded as unacceptable.

Without adequate information on both the quality of services expected and perceptions of services received then feedback from customer surveys can be highly misleading from both a policy and an operational perspective.

A leisure service, for example, may wish to assess customer satisfaction with its opening hours. While the results from this type of question on a customer feedback questionnaire may offer comfort to service managers – along the lines of "87 per cent of users indicated that they were satisfied with our opening hours" – they are of little use in trying to assess whether customers' needs and expectations are actually being met. Because there is no explicit measure of customer expectations, it is difficult to interpret responses to such questions in any definitive way. If opening hours are a critical aspect of customer expectations of leisure services then, despite an apparently high satisfaction score, the service might still be failing to meet customer expectations and, arguably worse still, failing to realise this. Perhaps more importantly, services may plan performance improvements on the basis of such information. Consider the leisure services which in the same survey found that 62 per cent of customers expressed satisfaction with the service's changing facilities. At face value, it appears that the service needs to improve its performance in relation to changing facilities rather than opening hours given the relative satisfaction scores. However, without evidence of relative expectations of the two aspects of service such prioritisation – and the resource reallocation likely to occur – may be incorrect. In diagnostic terms, then, such satisfaction scores are of dubious value in helping identify where performance improvement is most needed and where scarce resources would best be allocated to support such improvement.

Measuring service quality

Clearly, from a Best Value perspective the measurement of service quality in the public sector should take into account customer expectations of service as well as perceptions of service. However, as Robinson (1999) concludes that "It is apparent that there is little consensus of opinion and much disagreement (about how to measure service quality)". One service quality measurement model that has been extensively applied is the SERVQUAL model developed by Parasuraman *et al.* (1985, 1986, 1988, 1991, 1993, 1994). The

Managing Service Quality
Volume 11 · Number 6 · 2001 · 380–388

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SERVQUAL instrument comprises 22 statements used to assess service quality across five dimensions (Tangibles, Reliability, Responsiveness, Assurance, Empathy) with each statement used twice: once to measure expectations and once to measure perceptions. Parasuraman *et al.*, argue that, with minor modification, SERVQUAL can be adapted to any service organisation. They further argue that information on service quality gaps can help managers diagnose where performance improvement can best be targeted. The largest negative gaps, combined with assessment of where expectations are highest, facilitates prioritisation of performance improvement. Equally, if gap scores in some aspects of service do turn out to be positive, implying expectations are actually not just being met but exceeded, then this allows managers to review whether they may be "over-supplying" this particular feature of the service and whether there is potential for re-deployment of resources into features which are under-performing. This appears to be particularly relevant for public sector services with budgets increasingly under pressure.

Since the development of SERVQUAL it has been extensively applied (see Buttle 1996) leading Robinson (1999) to comment:

> There seems little doubt that ... SERVQUAL has proved to be the most popular instrument for measuring service quality.

The number of public sector applications, however, is relatively sparse with many of these in the US health sector with its pseudo-commercial characteristics. There are even fewer applications in local government (Dalrymple *et al.*, 1995; Donnelly *et al.*, 1995; Wisniewski and Donnelly, 1996; Donnelly and Shiu 1999). SERVQUAL has been extensively criticised on both theoretical and operational grounds (see Buttle, 1996 and Asubonteng *et al.*, 1996), although Asubonteng *et al.* (1996) conclude that:

> Until a better but equally simple model emerges, SERVQUAL will predominate as a service quality measure.

The pilot studies

Given the importance attached to councils "ensuring they understand the needs, expectations and priorities of all stakeholders" and the scarcity of UK local government applications of SERVQUAL, Audit Scotland undertook pilot work with SERVQUAL across a number of services in a number of councils primarily to assess the performance improvement information that the approach might be able to provide service managers. These pilot services were:

- *Catering service*: catering services to a councils' schools and other facilities.
- *Building control*: issuing building warrants and enforcing building regulations.
- *Development control*: dealing with applications for building developments.
- *Grounds maintenance*: maintaining the grounds and open spaces of leisure centres, schools and other council property.
- *Housing repairs*: providing a repair service to a council's housing tenants.
- *Leisure services*: operating a council's leisure facilities.
- *Library services*: operating a council's library facilities.

The focus of interest was on the information that the SERVQUAL approach might provide service managers from a service diagnostic perspective and how this information might support the drive for continuous improvement required of councils under Best Value. An adapted version of the SERVQUAL questionnaire was developed specifically for each service individually meaning that questionnaires used were not identical across services. A sample of service users were asked to complete the questionnaire with varying response rates and sample sizes from just under 100 to over 500.

Potential uses of SERVQUAL

There are a number of ways in which SERVQUAL results can be used to help services identify areas for performance improvement although, interestingly, this is an area little discussed in the literature. The key uses are described in turn.

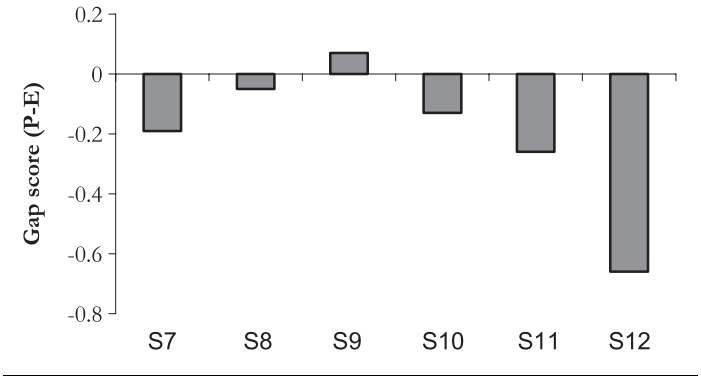
Understanding current service quality

The obvious use of gap scores is to enable the service manager to assess current service quality and quantify gaps that exist. Use of the service quality dimensions will allow an understanding of the broad areas where customers have particularly high – or low – expectations and an assessment of where

Managing Service Quality
Volume 11 · Number 6 · 2001 · 380–388

there may be relatively large gaps. Of more practical interest, however, a breakdown of a dimension into its constituent statements will then allow focusing on particular problem areas. The Library service obtained gap scores across the five service dimensions as shown in Table I. The gap scores for two of the five dimensions were positive implying that customer expectations were actually exceeded by the service provided – the library service was doing better in these areas than people had expected (all gap scores other than Empathy were statistically significantly different from zero at the 95 per cent level). There were two dimensions, however, Tangibles and Reliability, where gap scores were negative indicating that customer expectations were not being met. This implied that management action to close these gaps in particular was needed. Further prioritisation was possible by examining the level of expectations across these two dimensions. While the gap score was significantly higher than that for Reliability, the mean Expectations score for Reliability was significantly higher than that for Tangibles. Mean expectations for Tangibles was 5.7 but 6.1 for Reliability. The final stage was to examine the individual statements making up the Reliability dimension (Figure 1). It was clear that the largest service quality gap in this dimension was with statement 12 (S12) which related to the library having reliable equipment (photocopiers, Internet facilities, etc.) for library users. This enabled the service manager to identify specific areas for performance improvement that should have a direct impact on customer satisfaction.

Figure 1 Individual gap scores library service



Weights

Results can also be used to provide an overall understanding of the relative importance from the customer's perspective of the five service dimensions in terms of an individual service and across different services. The SERVQUAL instrument asks respondents to allocate weights out of 100 to each of the five dimensions (although a text description of each dimension is actually provided for respondents to weight). Table II shows the results. The importance attached to each dimension by customers varies markedly, with Reliability always having the highest weight (with the exception of Leisure services) and Empathy typically the lowest. For Tangibles, in particular, the weight varies considerably from 12 per cent in a Development Control service to 25 per cent for Grounds Maintenance. However, in spite of differences between the actual weights, there is considerable consistency on the rankings of these within each service. Reliability is ranked first by five out of the six services (and second by the remaining service), Responsiveness typically ranked second and Empathy last. Tangibles showed most variability in rankings. Potentially, this allows for resource prioritisation in terms of performance improvement. For example, information on Tangible weights across different services, together with information on gap scores across the Tangibles dimension, could be used to prioritise capital expenditure budgets. Weights and gap scores for Reliability could be used to prioritise systems and process improvements; weights and gap scores for the other three dimensions could be used to prioritise staff training programmes.

Comparing different customer groups

Few services, if any, will have customers who all have exactly the same needs and who all use the service in exactly the same way. Rather, services will face distinct and different customer segments. The gap analysis approach can be useful at comparing these. Are we, for example, achieving high levels of satisfaction with one

Table I Library service gap scores

Dimension	Tangibles	Reliability	Responsiveness	Assurance	Empathy
Gap score	– 0.25	– 0.20	+ 0.11	+ 0.29	+ 0.01

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Table II Dimension weights

Dimension	Catering service	Building control	Development control	Grounds maintenance	Housing repairs	Leisure services	Library service
Tangibles	20	12	12	25	15	23	18
Reliability	30	32	31	29	25	21	23
Responsiveness	20	23	22	16	22	19	22
Assurance	15	20	21	15	19	20	21
Empathy	15	14	14	15	19	17	16

customer segment but not with another? If so, what can we do about this? Development Control used the gap approach to assess service quality when dealing with planning applications from three distinct groups: those who had made the planning application themselves, agents acting on behalf of applicants and objectors to an application. There is a clear rationale for seeing objectors as a discrete customer group. The reason for distinguishing between applicants and agents was that the former are likely to be "one-off" customers, while the latter are more likely to be repeat customers dealing, over time, with a number of applications. Expectations and Perceptions, it was felt, might well be different. The results revealed that as far as Applicants and Agents were concerned their expectations were identical across three of the five dimensions, but that agents had higher expectations in both Tangibles and in Assurance. Analysing the individual statements under each dimension indicated that Agents' expectations were significantly higher for the features of the service relating to Tangibles (privacy for meetings/interviews with council staff, application forms that are easy to understand, structure and local plans that are easy to understand) and Assurance (fair and impartial decisions based on professional advice, staff dealing with matters in confidence). The survey also revealed that there were no significant differences in expectations between applicants and objectors. In other words, across the five dimensions both applicants and objectors expressed the same expectations of the service. Analysis of the gap scores, however, revealed that for objectors the Reliability dimension was particularly problematic, with this showing the largest negative gap score. Examination of individual statements in this dimension highlighted the major aspects of dissatisfaction to be related to: when staff promise to do something by a certain time they do so and to staff showing a sincere interest in trying to solve your problems. The implications of these findings were that, as far as objectors were concerned, staff were making promises to do things that they did not keep and that staff did not show any particular interest in helping resolve objectors' problems. This helped the service focus on where improvements would have most impact as far as these customers were concerned.

Comparing different parts of the service

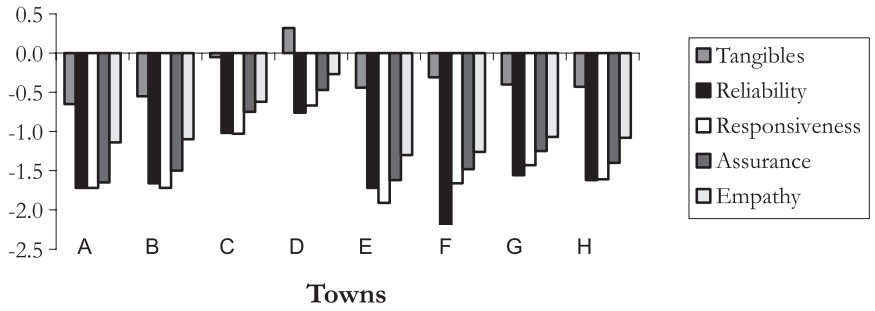
Gap analysis also allows comparisons to be made across different parts of the same service on a geographical basis. Many services operate with area "offices", branch libraries, for example. Comparison of expectations of customers within each area becomes possible; so does the identification of similar, or different, service quality gaps across areas. Housing Services operated eight area offices and the survey results were analysed for the service as a whole but also by area office. The gap scores are shown in Figure 2. There is a consistent difference across the five dimensions between the area offices C and D and the other offices. These two area offices consistently have smaller gap scores than the rest implying that they are closer to meeting tenants' expectations. Interestingly, the analysis also revealed that customer expectations in each of the dimensions did not vary across the eight offices. That is, tenants had broadly the same levels of expectations of the service no matter where they lived. Such information clearly allows for internal benchmarking.

Understanding the internal customer

In order to deliver service quality to the external customer it is well recognised that internal customer service must also be of the right quality. In any organisation there exists the service chain – the inter-connected activities across the whole organisation that deliver the service to the final customer

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Figure 2 Housing services: gap scores by town



(Heskett *et al.*, 1994). Like any chain it is only as strong as its weakest link and the service received by the external customer will be inadequate if internal customer service is not delivered (Nagel and Cilliers, 1990; Davis, 1991; Feldman, 1991; Jablonski, 1992). Grönroos (1990), for example, describes the service process as a network of systems built between a number of sub-processes, arguing that every service operation comprises inter-connected internal service functions and that, if poor internal service exists, then the final service to the external customer will be inadequate. However, as Marshall *et al.* (1998) comment:

> . . . internal service quality is one of the most important and least understood concepts in modern business.

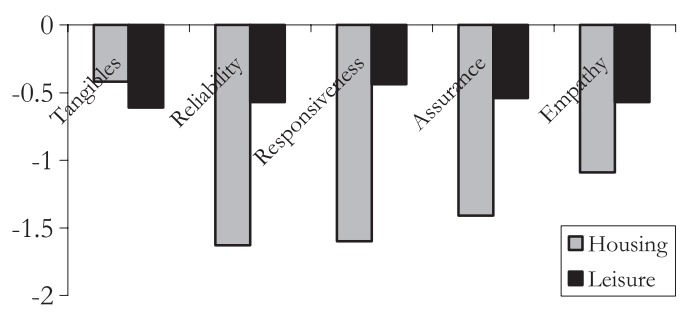
The Grounds maintenance service applied the gap approach to its internal "customers": those staff from its client departments. These fell into four main customer segments: schools, community centres, housing deptartment and sports centres. The contractual service between the service and its clients was currently a standard one, effectively providing the same to all client departments. Analysis of the findings on expectations, however, revealed significant differences between clients. Although expectations were the same in three dimensions, in Tangibles and in Empathy there were statistically significant differences. For schools and housing the largest individual gap occurred around the issue of work being carried out on a regular basis. For community centres and sports centres it was about facilities (such as play equipment and seats) being well-maintained. Analysis of the individual statements making up each dimension enabled managers to assess the critical areas of difference, as they were developing the next contract specification for their internal clients.

Comparing services

Results from gap-based surveys can also be used to compare services. Such comparison might be within a particular council where different services have used similar surveys. It could also be between councils where similar services have used a comparable survey. Housing and leisure services within the same council both used the gap questionnaire although there were differences in individual statements within each dimension to tailor the questionnaire to each service. Leisure services faced higher levels of expectation across all dimensions although the most noticeable difference between the two services was for tangibles. Potentially this has implications for resource allocation between the services and for resource prioritisation within each service. Figure 3 shows the gap scores for each dimension for the two services. Leisure does consistently "better" across all dimensions except the Tangibles even though it faced higher customer expectations. There are opportunities for both services in term of process or strategic benchmarking. Leisure could see how housing is able to generate a small quality gap in tangibles compared to itself. Housing could usefully benchmark against the other four dimensions.

The gap approach was also introduced independently in the development control services in two councils. Although there were

Figure 3 Gap scores: housing and leisure



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Managing Service Quality
Volume 11 · Number 6 · 2001 · 380–388

differences in the detailed questionnaire design and selected customer samples, the service managers informally compared results. In both councils the overall profile of gap score results across the five dimensions was quite similar. However, Council A appeared to be doing "better" than Council B in the assurance dimension in particular, while Council B was doing comparatively better in reliability. Such results enabled managers to compare with their counterparts in other councils as part of benchmarking and continuous improvement. Is it because of resource availability, different systems and procedures, different staff training? Such questions are particularly relevant to these two services since further analysis revealed that customer expectations across the five dimensions did not differ significantly between the two councils.

Performance over time

One of the prime purposes of such performance measurement is to allow action to be taken to close significant gaps in service provision. Repeating the gap survey over time allows the service to track whether actions taken have closed gaps and whether new gaps are appearing. Leisure services repeated the survey a year later. Gap scores for four of the five dimensions were unchanged, but that for tangibles had increased (the service had experienced major budget cuts during this period). Analysis of the statements revealed two aspects of tangibles in particular where performance was perceived to have worsened significantly: having up-to-date facilities and having facilities that were visually appealing. Comparison across different facilities revealed that these problems were seen as particularly severe in one specific leisure centre.

Evaluation of the pilot studies

While SERVQUAL has been criticised from both a theoretical and operational perspective (for example see Buttle, 1996), it is still seen by many as the most appropriate method of trying to measure customer satisfaction (Dotchin and Oakland, 1994a, 1994b). It was clear from all the pilot services that the gap approach was conceptually attractive to service managers and the gap results seen as being of considerable operational benefit, supplementing information already available. This supports Asubonteng's (1996) view that:

> SERVQUAL is popular with managers because it combines ease of application and flexibility with a clear and uninvolved theory. Managers know that results obtained using the model are probably not objective truth but that they help identify the direction in which the firm should move.

Most of the services involved in the pilots are continuing to use the SERVQUAL approach as part of their routine performance measurement.

There were, however, a number of pertinent issues arising from the pilot study. The first of these relates to the internal capacity of the service to undertake this kind of research. Typically, these services and their councils had little, or no, quantitative research support available in-house. This meant there was little, if any, expertise in terms of questionnaire design, survey methodology, sampling techniques or statistical analysis. Without external support it is highly unlikely that this work would have been undertaken at all, or that it would have been undertaken as rigorously as it was. The second major issue related to the difficulties in trying to ensure a random sample of customers. None of the services had the resources to use professional market research organisations for the logistics of the survey but had to use their own staff. In some cases, the lack of detailed information about customers meant it was difficult to assess how random or representative the sample was. The third issue related to the complexity of the SERVQUAL questionnaire. The questionnaire itself is relatively complicated with pairs of statements designed to capture responses on both expectations and perceptions and the relative importance of dimensions (through weights). A detailed set of instructions on how to complete the questionnaire is necessary. There was anecdotal evidence that some customers were deterred from completing the questionnaire because of its apparent length and complexity. The final issue related to the reporting of the gap scores. While service managers were comfortable with the principle of negative gap scores, and the fact that any organisation would typically expect negative rather than positive scores (Dotchin and Oakland 1994a, 1994b) they had major concerns about reporting these to staff, to elected members and to the public. Their concern was that a negative score, no matter how small, would automatically be seen as service failure. Some services decided instead to report the results using a service quality scale of 0 to 6, where 0 would represent a gap score

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of -6 (the largest possible) and 6 would represent a gap score of 0.

Summary

Managers in the public sector are under increasing pressure to demonstrate that their services are customer-focused and that continuous performance improvement is being delivered. Given the financial and resource constraints under which public sector organisations must manage it is essential that customer expectations are properly understood and measured and that, from the customers' perspective, any gaps in service quality are identified. This information then assists a manager in identifying cost-effective ways of closing service quality gaps and of prioritising which gaps to focus on – a critical decision given scarce resources. SERVQUAL, as a method of measuring service quality, has attracted both widespread support and criticism. The overall conclusion from this pilot work is that public sector service managers find the gap approach and the dimension approach both conceptually attractive and operationally useful. For most of the services taking part, this was very often the first time they had had numerical information on customer expectations and hence on service quality gaps and the information generated was seen as useful, typically supplementing that already available to the service from focus groups, complaints systems and internal information systems. Based on the pilot work, and in the absence of another dominant service quality measurement model, the Accounts Commission for Scotland (1999b) published a detailed guide to the approach which has been widely distributed in Scotland's local authorities to help support their efforts to better understand customer satisfaction and their search for continuous improvement. Nevertheless, there is clearly a need for further research and investigation into the measurement of service quality in the public sector. Parasuraman *et al.*'s original argument that SERVQUAL's five dimensions are transportable to other service sectors remains to be verified in the UK public sector at least. Equally, the behaviour of expectations of public sector service over time is an area for investigation. With an increasing tendency for target and standard setting in many parts of the public sector (waiting times for health treatment, response times for emergency services, attainment levels of pupils in education, for example) their impact on both expectations and perceptions of service remains unknown.

However, it is also evident that SERVQUAL by itself, useful though it may be to a service manager, will not give a complete picture of needs, expectations and perceptions in a public sector context. As Gaster (1995) comments, because service provision in the public sector is more complex:

> [It] is not simply a matter of meeting expressed needs, but of finding out unexpressed needs, setting priorities, allocating resources and publicly justifying and accounting for what has been done.

Public sector services are responsible and accountable to citizens and communities as well as to customers and service users. There are wider public sector agendas than simply service quality: improving access to existing services; equity and equality of service provision; providing efficient and effective services within political as well as resource constraints; contributing to the wider public good. The definition of service quality in the public sector therefore takes on a wider meaning than in the private sector and accordingly its measurement becomes both more complex and more difficult.

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